PHOTOGRAPHY

# A SHARED LOSS

***Endangered Spaces***, a joint exhibition by a French and an Indian photographer, processes the fragility of their respective universes

The French photographer's figures stand out from the environment they're in... there, but not quite there. Her 'red phantoms' are juxtaposed against the starkly beautiful landscapes and crumbling architecture creating a deep sense of foreboding. The Indian photographer's figures are very real, deeply human, and yet, they become a part of the earthy backdrops they inhabit. Hélène Guétary's work is from her 'Zeitgeist' series, while Jayesh Sharma's is titled 'Kushti: The lost children of post-modernism'. Both have come together in the show titled *Endangered Spaces*, which has been curated by Anurag Kanoria. After exhibiting in Kolkata's Indian Museum, it is now **on at Nine Fish Art Gallery, Mumbai, until May 31.**

As different as both photographers as well as their styles and subjects are, there is still a sliver of commonality in what they seem to be seeking through their work and the way their protagonists process the fragility of their respective universes. When you see the dramatic images staged by Guétary in a multitude of locations, from jungles to opera houses, from the Caribbean to the canals of Venice, you understand the vulnerability of each geography but also its transcendent beauty—at once ephemeral and eternal.

Sharma, who was born in Varanasi, understands the fast-disappearing world of the *akhara* and the cloistered lives of the wrestlers who frequent it. To see years of traditional upbringing and ritualistic disciplines of these 'pahalwans' finding less and less meaning within the newer constructs of modernism has been a challenging and sad process for Sharma. He has documented this microcosm, capturing moments of contemplation that showcase sensitivity and inner strength rather than brute force, often using natural light to convey a certain mood.



In *Endangered Spaces*, the duo's work counterbalances and dovetails in the most surprising way, giving you a lot to process even as you enjoy the artistry of the visuals. "Guétary and Sharma confront the pivotal point that we stand at today, in a world poised on the edge of change—a rather ambiguous and vacillating space between the relentless spate of globalisation with dreams of incorporating all people into a singular universal society and the tenacious and persistent undertow of a slew of diversely lived memories of traditions that do not seem to let go. Perhaps here is where the two photographers diverge in their practices of grappling with the world," muses Kanoria. "Both seem acutely aware of the legacy of 'the Modern' and its post-modern transformations, so to say, but come at it with the respective weights of their own traditions as they confront the landscapes of loss, longing, and hope." ■

**—Priya Pathiyan**





**A LENS DUET** (Clockwise from top) Jayesh Sharma with Hélène Guétary; a photo shot in India that is part of Guétary's 'Zeitgeist' collection; an exhibit from Sharma's 'Kushti: The lost children of post-modernism' series